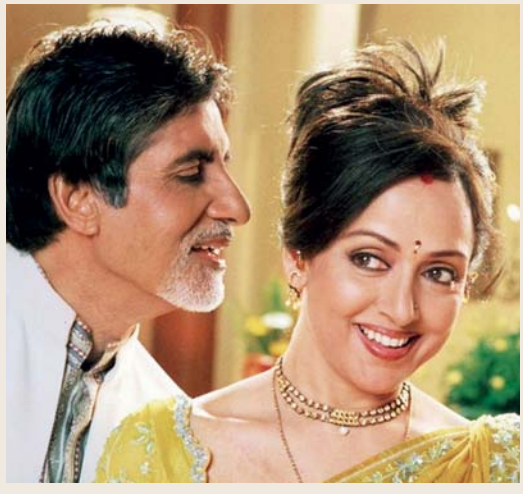


By HEMA MALINI

"Amitji is a unique phenomenon"

Seldom in the annals of Indian public life has an individual garnered so much respect and adoration as Amitji has done in his long, eventful career as a film artist and public figure. From his days when he assumed a screen persona of an 'angry young man' to a polished host of TV shows, Amitji has traversed complex terrains with ease. All have been accomplished without compromising on the aesthetics that surround his every movement. It's heartening to see him enter his 80th year with the same verve that marked his entry into films some 50 years ago. I was fortunate to share film and public space with Amitji and will cherish the hits we delivered. The world may not see such a unique phenomenon for a long, long time. ■

***Actress Hema Malini has worked with Amitabh Bachchan in films like* Sholay, Trishul *and* Baghban (below)**



(1969) performed that historic function, but done by the old writer-director Khwaja Ahmad Abbas—the man behind *Dharti Ke Lal* (1946) and many of Raj Kapoor's films—his idealistic vein also kept it off-Broadway, so to speak. The mainstream largely shunned the tall, gangly youth for a few more years, with only a trickle of minor films coming his way. Navin Nishchol, who debuted a year after Bachchan, rose to stardom faster—and got paid more. It was still a world made for romantic heroes with *khubani ka meetha* faces. So nobody could have anticipated what happened thereafter.

A supporting role in Hrishikesh Mukherjee's *Anand* (1971) was a bend in the road—even next to the bravura, author-backed role of superstar Rajesh Khanna, Bachchan's quiet intensity filtered through. Filmmakers slowly learnt to harness that flame. Finally, *Zanjeer* (1973) scaled that up to full-scale arson. Bachchan's honest cop, tormented by inner and outer demons, burst forth on the Seventies with such a primal force that it caught the zeitgeist. It was a time of inner ferment for the nation and its youth, beginning to chafe in such rage at the corrupt, stagnant system that the Emergency was soon imposed in a vain bid to bottle it up. Bachchan's 'Angry Young Man' became the very embodiment of that larger storm. And stayed there, like a one-man forest fire, through the decade and beyond. With films like *Deewaar*, *Sholay*, *Trishul*, *Don*, *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* and *Kaala Patthar*, what changed was not merely Amitabh Bachchan's fate, but the very heart and culture of Hindi cinema. Its very tone and tenor. Through those times, he towered over everything precisely because he had co-authored those times, like some deity in an act of Creation.

For those who came in late, there were more unbelievable twists in the plot—careening between the demigodly status and destitution. A bout of injury and ill health, a diversion to politics that ended as ignominiously as it started gloriously, a filmography that sputtered down to largely inconsequential films that sought to ride on his past popularity without ever recreating anything like his past incandescence, and then a fateful turn to business. A company was set up that dared to think big but managed to end small...very small. As the century wound down, the Amitabh Bachchan Corporation Limited was winding up in bankruptcy—and taking down a human piece of history with it. Then as the clock struck the new millennium, the pendulum swung again to the other side. A remarkable second innings started. *Kaun Banega Crorepati* (*KBC*), a quiz show on Star TV, got Bachchan right into drawing rooms...and people reacted as if divinity was paying a visitation in humanised form. And slowly, the films started striking a second burst of efflorescence too—like a Nilgiri kurinji plant flowering after a gap of 14 years. Why is Amitabh Bachchan a piece of living history? Because that phase, again unbelievably, is still with us.